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COMPSCI 160
Summer 2026
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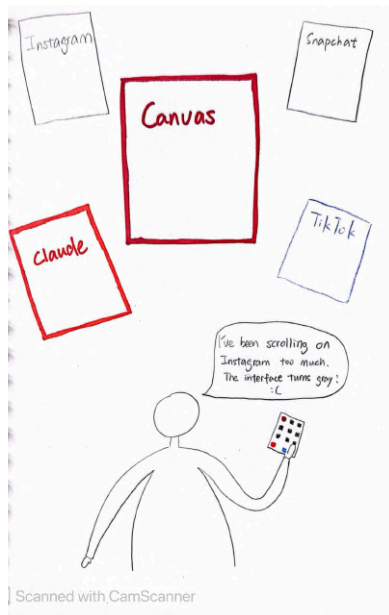
Project Milestone 2: Lo-Fi Prototyping

1. Sketching & Brainstorming:

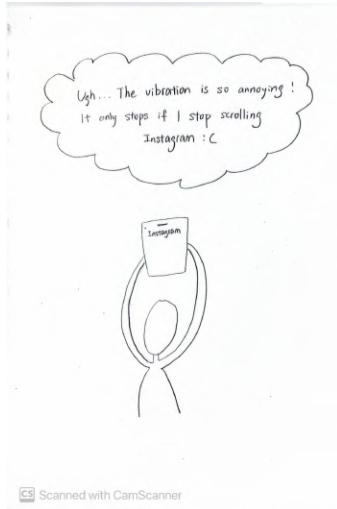
Each team member independently selected two rough ideas from Milestone 1 that they wanted to explore further. Using divergent brainstorming techniques, we expanded each concept into 2-3 distinct variations. Our brainstorming explored different interaction modalities, including web and mobile applications, browser extensions, wearable smart glasses, AR/VR, and physical interfaces.

Rough Idea 1: Turn distracting apps to gray-scale, and keep the essential apps in color.

Distinct idea 1: Users can select the apps that they think are distracting. The app button and interfaces of the rest of the apps keep colorful, but the longer the users stay on the distraction apps, the grayer the interfaces and the app buttons become.



Distinct idea 2: Users can customize all their apps to either essential apps or distraction apps. As soon as they open the distraction apps, the phone will keep vibrating until they stop using the distraction apps.

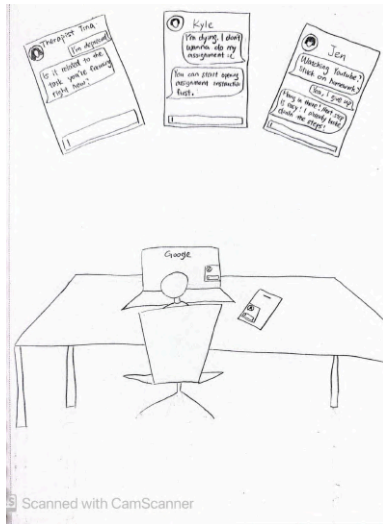


Distinct idea 3: Users can customize all their apps to either essential apps or distraction apps. After the users wear the meta glass, the distraction apps will turn gray through glass, and users can choose their favorite virtual themes, such as Star Wars, or ocean world. The longer they study, the more vivid the virtual space is.

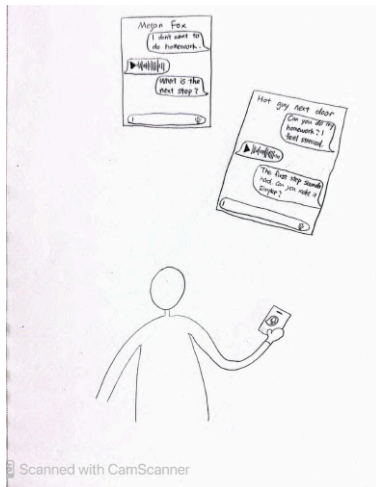


Rough Idea 2: A user-chosen chatbot encourages users as a friend, a role the user wants it to be, or a therapist encourages users to start a task, help break them down, and provide emotional support.

Distinct idea 1: Phone or computer plugin AI chatbot to guide and encourage users to do tasks and help users stay focused when they switch to distraction apps/websites. In addition, users can chat with the chatbots when they are emotional.



Distinct idea 2: Plugin customised chatbot's voice, speaking speed, and tone as a therapist, friend or help users to manage their tasks.

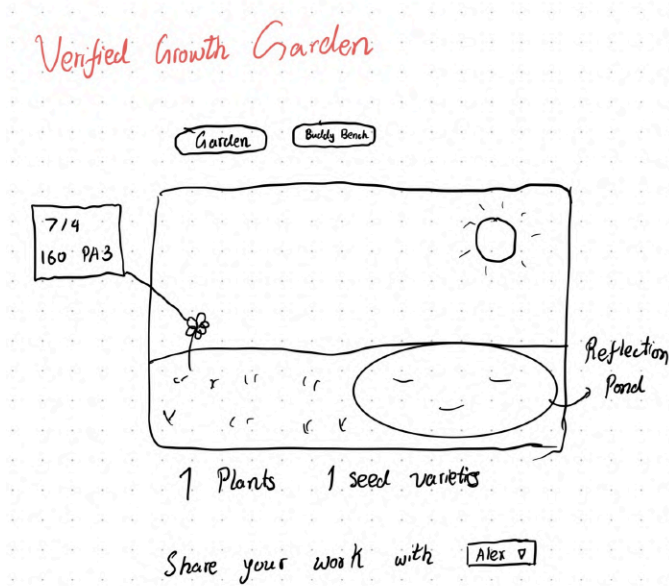


Distinct idea 3: Users can see the customized chatbot when they wear their AR/VR glasses. It can guide users to their essentials and stay in the virtual world studying with the users as a study buddy.

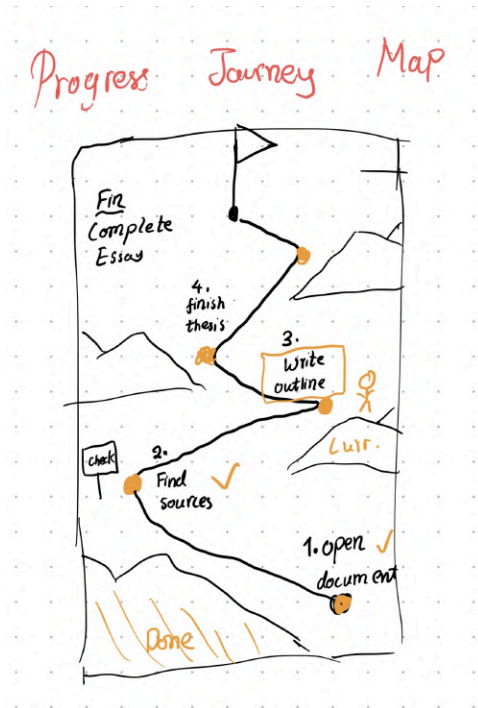


Rough Idea 3: Visual progress tracker with more progress when task is verified. Keeps the reward system but doesn't let it be gamed or fakeable the way Habitica or Finch do.

Distinct idea 1: Growth garden where verified sessions grow faster than self-reported ones. Each task is a seed or plant. When the user completes a verified work session, the plant grows faster, blooms, or gains fruit. Self-reported work still grows the plant, but more slowly. Optional ambient noise.

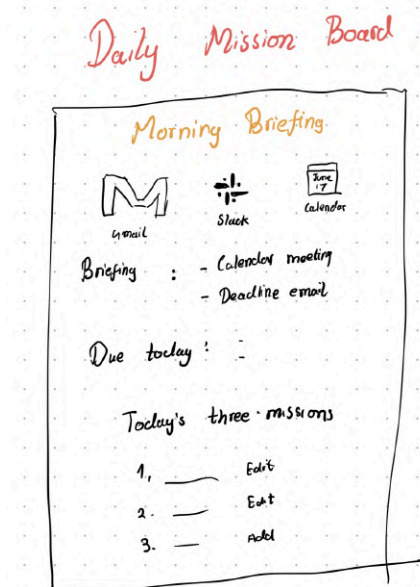


Distinct idea 2: Progress Journey Map. Progress is shown as movement through the map with the immediate next step. Each task is a trail, staircase, or map. The user moves a character forward with each real work session, passing checkpoints like "started," "outline," "draft," "done."



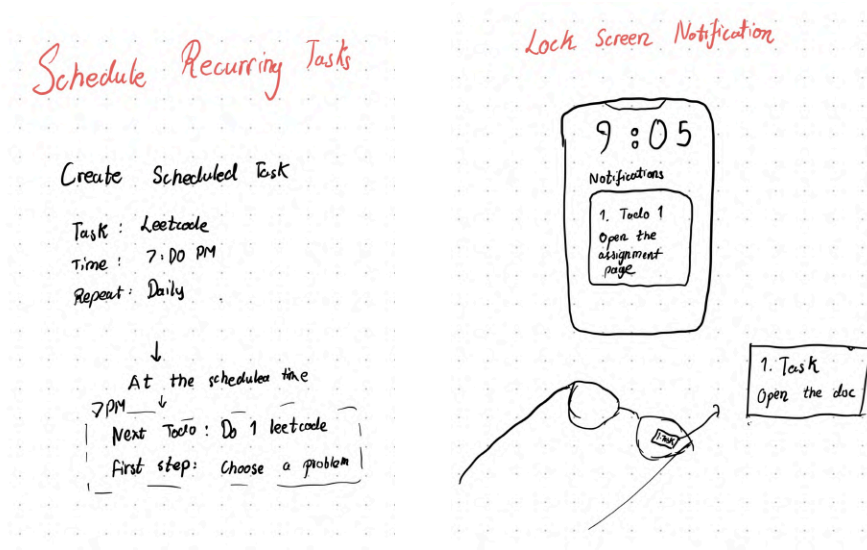
Rough Idea 4: Unified tasks briefings and schedule recurring task prompts that turn scattered responsibilities into a bounded daily plan.

Distinct idea 1: Weekly and Morning Briefings Dashboard. The system pulls together items from Gmail, Slack, and Calendar into one bounded plan. A weekly briefing helps the user preview what is coming, and a morning briefing narrows it into today's top tasks.



Distinct idea 2: Lock Screen Next-To-Do Prompt for Recurring Tasks Users set recurring scheduled tasks (ex: laundry, study block, clean desk, journaling). At the scheduled time, the

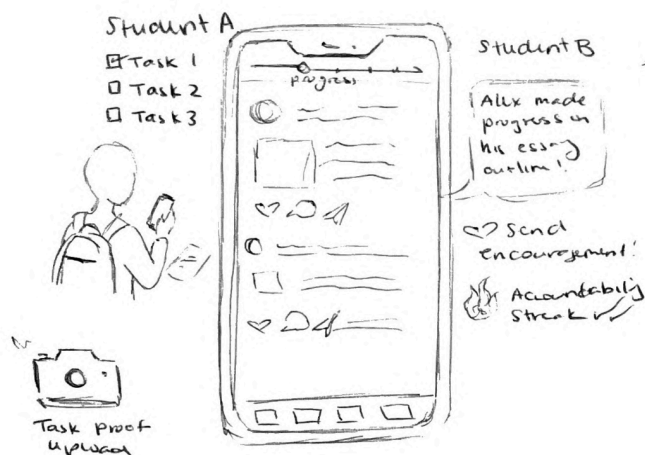
phone lock screen shows the single next to-do, so the user does not have to open an app and figure out what to do.



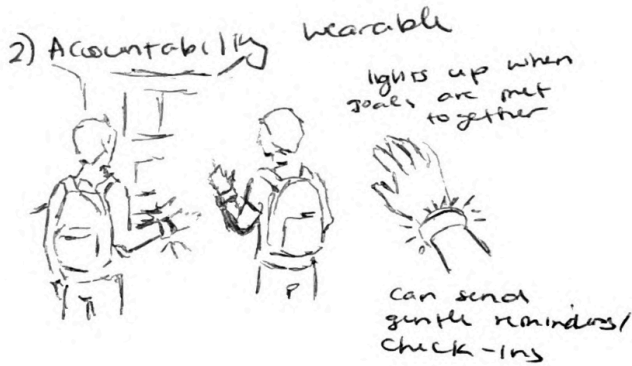
Rough Idea 5: Buddy system with photo or screenshot progress sharing (matching anonymous or with friends). Replaces self checked boxes with something a friend can actually see.

Distinct idea 1: A home-screen widget prompts users to upload photo proof of completed tasks, send encouragement, track shared streaks, and set weekly goals with an accountability partner. The widget keeps accountability visible throughout the day.

1) Accountability Buddy App 2)



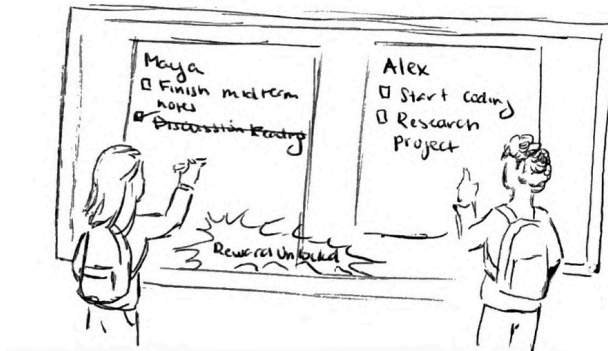
Distinct idea 2: A smartwatch or wearable device sends gentle buzzes as reminders, celebrates completed goals, and prompts users to check in with their accountability partner. Mutual progress updates help keep both users motivated.



Distinct idea 3: A collaborative task board for roommates or dormmates where users move task cards from "To Do" to "Done." The board gamifies progress with shared goals, rewards, and encouragement, creating visible accountability within a shared living space.

3) Study Room Accountability Wall

in shared dorm area



Rough Idea 6: Thought dumping tool for users to write down their worries and tasks occupying their mind. The system organizes them into categories (e.g., "do now," "do later," or "not important")

Distinct idea 1: A voice-based assistant allows students to verbally unload everything occupying their mind without needing to organize their thoughts first. The system analyzes their concerns and transforms them into clear next steps.

4) Brain Dump + Stress Sorting App



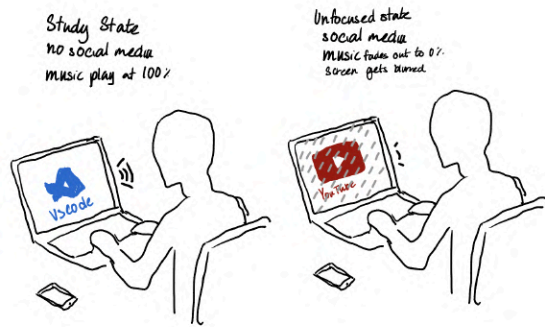
Distinct idea 2: A physical object that helps students externalize and organize their thoughts by turning invisible mental clutter into a visible plan. Students can write down their worries on sticky notes or on paper and a mirror, wall display, or pin board can organize thoughts into categories like “Act Now,” “Plan for Later,” “Release/Reframe”

5) Desk Mirror Worry Sorter



Rough Idea 7: Browser extension that connects to a music streaming platform and only plays when the user is active on their assigned task page. If they navigate away to a distracting site, the music immediately stops playing, warns them to go back to work, and plays a distinct timeout alert sound.

Distinct idea 1: If the user navigates out from study tabs (bCourses, VS Code), the music starts to fade from its original volume down to zero. At the same time, a blur filter pops up over the non-academic website to block distracting content.



Distinct idea 2: If the user navigates out from study tabs (bCourses, VS Code), the music starts to fade from its original volume down to zero with a pop-up window with motivational quotes for them to lock back in.



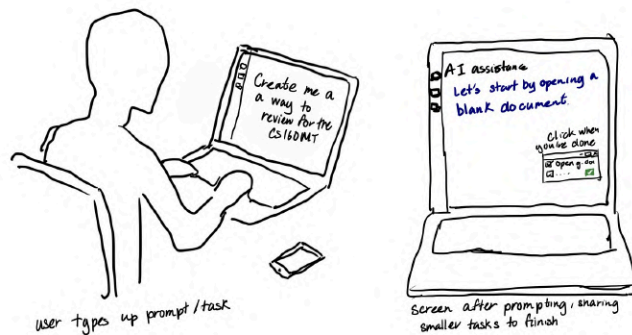
Distinct idea 3: If the user navigates out from study tabs (bCourses, VS Code), the music starts to fade from its original volume down to zero. At the same time, a blur filter pops up over the non-academic website to block distracting content as well as a vibration on your phone as the extension is connected to Bluetooth.



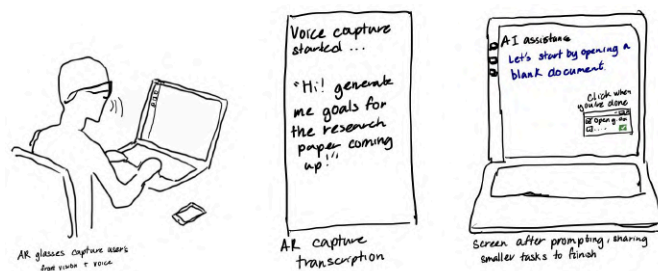
Rough Idea 8: Tiny first step generator on every task. Break a task down to one opener to start with.

Distinct idea 1: The user interacts with a dedicated desktop assistant on their touchscreen laptop. They enter their massive task into a chat interface. The assistant immediately breaks it down,

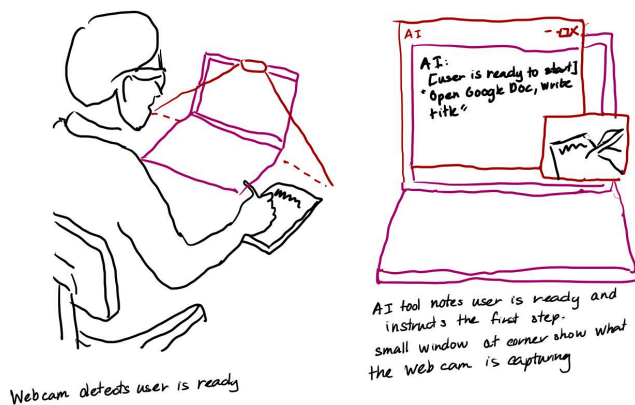
generating and displaying only one single, small sub-task at a time to serve as the opener. The user physically taps the touchscreen to check it off, which prompts the chat to reveal the next step.



Distinct idea 2: The user wears AR glasses while working on their laptop. As they verbally explain concepts out loud and physically work through their first micro-steps, the AR glasses capture their audio and physical actions. The system automatically structures this into an AI-generated study summary that floats as a digital window right next to their real laptop screen, allowing them to look back at their progress and easily copy-paste the text directly into their main digital documents.



Distinct idea 3: The user's laptop webcam will monitor the workspace, and when a task is entered a small window pops up with the opener task and cycles through until the task is finished through computer vision as it lights up after every small step completion.



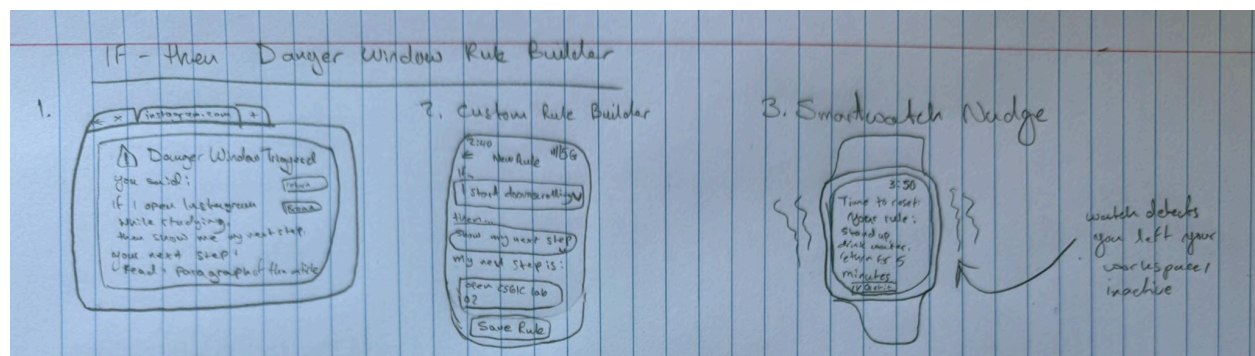
Rough Idea 9: if- then rule builder that's tied to a "danger window" where users identify their personal triggers and actions they can take to overcome them. for example: "if i start doomscrolling, i will set a 5-minute timer to reset"

Distinct idea 1: Before beginning a task the user identifies their personal "danger window" and creates an if-then rule. For example "if I open Instagram while studying, then show me the one small action I should return to". the system intervenes at the exact moment avoidance begins.

Distinct idea 2: a smartwatch detects when the user leaves their workspace or becomes inactive during a planned focus session. It sends a gentle vibration and displays the user's personally chosen reset action, such as "stand up, drink water, and return for just five minutes"

Distinct idea 3: a browser extension detects when the user leaves their selected work tabs and enters a distracting website. Instead of completely blocking the site, it asks the user to choose between returning to work, taking an international 5 minute break, or ending the focus session.

Sketches for the 3 ideas:



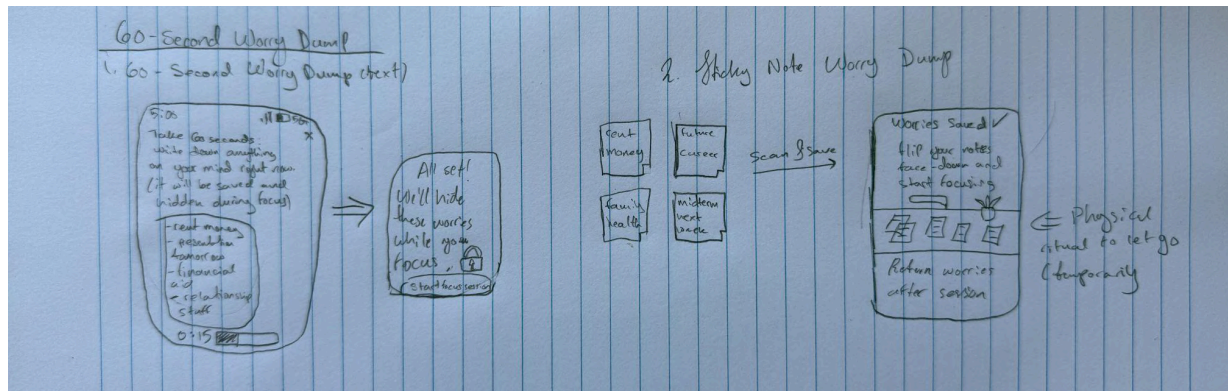
Rough Idea 10: a 60 second text prompt where the user writes out all of their current academic and non-academic worries, such as rent, financial aid, relationships, or errands and temporarily stores them during the focus session to prevent distractions.

Distinct idea 1: the user verbally speaks all their worries into their phone before they start the work, the system converts them into short cards and separates them into categories such as "handle today", "handle later", and "outside my control". only the current task remains visible during the work session.

Distinct idea 2: before starting work, the user gets 60 seconds to type every unrelated worry currently occupying their mind. The worries disappear into a hidden "parking lot" during the focus session and return afterward so the user knows they have not been forgotten.

Distinct idea 3: a physical/digital system where the user writes each worry on a sticky note and places it beneath a phone or tablet camera. The device digitally stores each concern and instructs the user to physically turn the sticky notes face down until the focus session ends, creating a visible ritual for temporarily setting anxieties aside.

Sketches for idea 1 and 3:



2. Funneling In

Distinct realization 1: Turn distracting apps to gray-scale, and keep the essential apps in color. Users can select the apps that they think are distracting. The app button and interfaces of the rest of the apps keep colorful, but the longer the users stay on the distraction apps, the grayer the interfaces and the app buttons become.

1. What makes this solution unique enough to be explored?

Fixes the issue of sense of invasion and boredom of other discipline apps. It serves as a gentle and intelligent accountability partner 24/7 rather than a cold-hearted officer. This can attract and maintain more users because it's not aggressive like other discipline apps to set a time or lock the app. So users will feel less irritated or intimidated by the function, so users will be less likely to give up on this anti-addiction journey. The color transitions make users feel more comfortable and can be a natural reminder of phone use. It can build longer and more stable relationships with users.

2. What modalities are in-play here?

Mobile App first (larger user base), might extend to Web later

3. What are some pros and some cons for each of these?

Pros are people don't need to mentally prepare for any sudden app shut down. The grayscale is much more gradual than cold turkey quitting. People don't need to learn anything to use this app, so the method can build relationships with a lot of users. Cons are people might build tolerance towards the grayscale.

Distinct realization 2: Unified weekly, morning and night briefings that turn scattered responsibilities into a bounded daily plan.

1. What makes this solution unique enough to be explored?

It doesn't add another to-do list. It pulls obligations already scattered across Gmail, Slack, and Calendar into one bounded plan and keeps narrowing the day down to a single next action, closing the loop from a morning briefing to a night reflection. That directly targets the "I feel like something is due" dread and the initiation gap our interviews surfaced, where the barrier was never information or planning, it was starting. Instead of requiring users to repeatedly check several platforms and remember scattered obligations, the system automatically consolidates them and helps the user turn them into a manageable daily plan.

2. What modalities are in-play here?

Mobile App, Web App, Audio. A mobile or web dashboard, integrations with Gmail, Slack, and Google Calendar, and optional phone notifications. Audio is included because a spoken morning briefing removes the "open and read on a screen" step on low-energy mornings where friction might be the highest.

3. What are some pros and some cons for each of these?

Consolidating Gmail, Slack, and Calendar into one bounded plan for the day, with a single next action directly targets the "something is due" anxiety dread/overwhelm and the initiation gap from our interviews, and it meets users in tools they already use daily. The con is that it needs broad account access and reliable due-date parsing which are both hard and privacy-sensitive.

Distinct realization 3: Accountability Companions App, that allows users to set both personal and shared goals with their friends, track task progress, send encouragement, maintain shared streaks, and stay accountable. Through an optional AR mode, users can also study alongside a friend or accountability buddy in a shared virtual workspace, creating a stronger sense of co-presence while working.

1. What makes this solution unique enough to be explored?

AR Presence reimagines accountability through supportive co-presence. Users can share progress signals, emotional states, and requests for support from friends or accountability buddies. This creates accountability without shame, making it more accessible for users with ADHD and anxiety.

2. What modalities are in-play here?

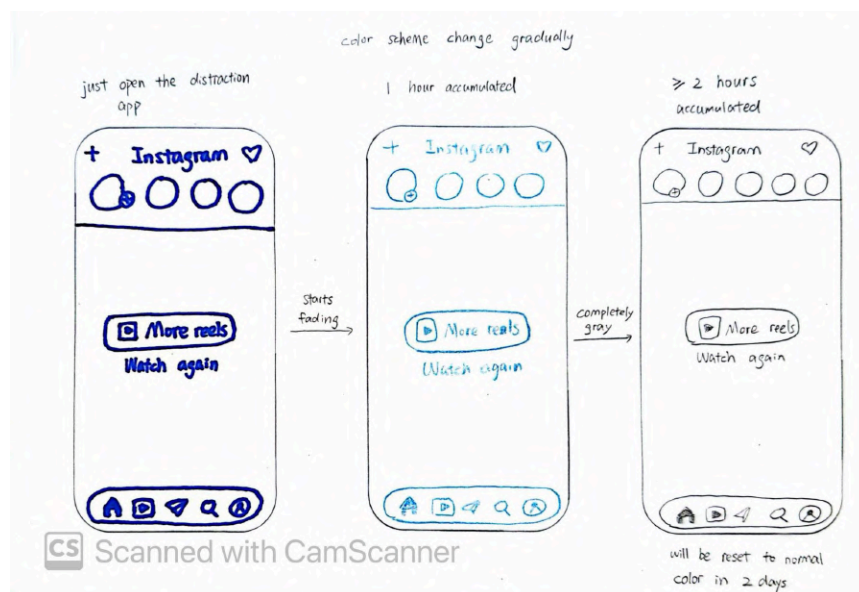
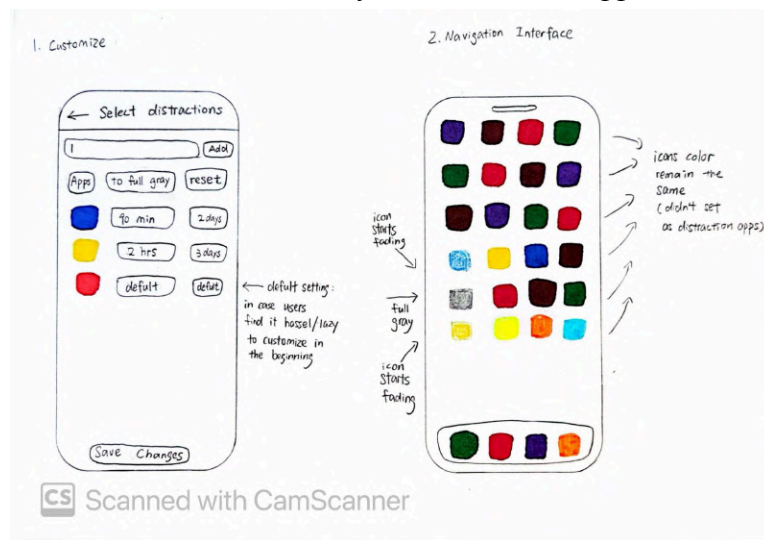
Mobile Phone App, Widget, AR

3. What are some pros and some cons for each of these?

Shared progress and supportive co-presence creates accountability without shame, which fits users with ADHD who abandon high pressure systems, and the support request feature helps users at the low energy moments. The con is that it depends on the buddies reliably showing up and the user being comfortable with sharing their progress. Users with rejection sensitivity might fear being judged which can push them to avoid or quit the app.

3. Concept Sketches with Pros and Cons

Distinct realization 1: Grayscale distraction apps



Pro 1: Fixed the issue of sense of invasion and boredom of other discipline apps. No sudden lock-down, minimal mentally preparation.

Pro 2: Mobile apps, easy and clear navigation, and gentle transitions will attract and maintain broader users - both professionals and people who don't go to school or desktop work.

Pro 3: Minimal design and instant feedback - no complicated or excessive feedback or extra clicks to see the feedback, feedback is straightforward and easy to see.

Pro 4: The visual change can motivate the users to stop passive doomscrolling, forming a healthier habit and improve the sharpness of the brain and memory in the long term. Decreasing passive scrolling improves cognition and brain function, allowing users to focus on their goals.

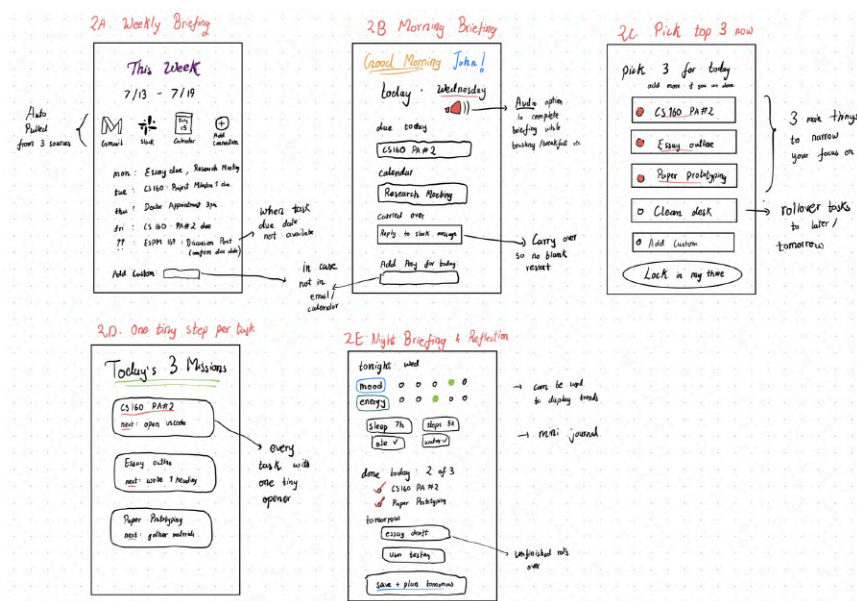
Con 1: Some users might build tolerance to the grayscale and ignore it eventually.

Con 2: Some users might delete the app or customize the distraction apps as essentials if they think it's annoying.

Con 3: A few apps can serve as both essential and distraction like Youtube videos and Youtube shorts, so it's hard to categorize in some situations.

Con 4: Users might feel uncomfortable sharing privacy with the app.

Distinct realization 2: Unified weekly, morning and night briefings



Pro 1: Reduces scattered information and reduces the stress of wondering whether something was forgotten, provides both weekly and daily views, combining obligations from Gmail, Slack and calendar, and manually added tasks into one place. Targets the “out of sight, out of mind” pattern in many ADHD individuals.

Pro 2: Lowers initiation cost and limits daily cognitive overload. The system narrows a large weekly workload into three priorities and one immediate next action like (“next: open vscode”), which matches the finding that the gap was starting, not planning.

Pro 3: Offers multiple ways to engage. Users can access the briefing through a mobile app, web dashboard, audio summary or lock screen/smart glass notification.

Pro 4: Meets users where they already are. It pulls from tools they live in and use already, and closes the full daily loop. Morning to midday to night with rollover means unfinished work carries forward, so users never face a blank restart.

Con 1: The briefing could become overwhelming if it imports too much information.

Con 2: Connecting private accounts may raise privacy concerns. Users may be uncomfortable giving the system access to email, messages, calendars, and personal tasks.

Con 3: Automatic task detection may make mistakes and be inaccurate. The system could miss an obligation or misunderstand a message and identify something irrelevant as a task.

Con 4: It requires setup and continued maintenance: Users must connect accounts, review imported information, and correct the plan when schedules change.

Distinct realization 3: Buddy system for Accountability



4) Support in real time

When working async
can place AR avatars
- send small messages
for a quick boost



5) Reflect

celebrate progress
together and keep
building better
habits



Pro 1: Encourages consistent focus through gentle accountability rather than pressure, reducing the shame that often causes people with ADHD and anxiety to abandon productivity systems.

Pro 2: Creates a sense of co-presence by allowing friends to focus together remotely, helping users feel supported without requiring constant messaging or video calls

Pro 3: Breaks overwhelming tasks into micro-steps and celebrates progress instead of perfect streaks, making it easier for users to recover after setbacks and maintain long-term engagement

Pro 4: Encourages individual and share goal setting as well as check ins with friends

Con 1: As users check their progress or log their tasks, they may become distracted by social media, games, or other distractions on their phone

Con 2: Relies on other people to act as an “accountability buddies” to pull user out of a low-energy state

Con 3: Setting up shared weekly goals and aligning calendars can require a lot of upfront cognitive investment that can make it too overwhelming to start

Con 4: Uploading or checking off tasks is a very tedious process. Rejection sensitive dysphoria can be a major blocker; fear of judgement from other users may lead them to abandon the app entirely

4. Final Design Selection

We chose **Unified Briefings (Distinct Realization 2 from Step 3)** because the idea targets the actual barrier our interviews surfaced which is initiation and cognitive overload, not information or planning. One participant had every prerequisite ready for a year (number found, script written, insurance card saved) and still couldn't begin because the task had no bounded start or end. By pulling scattered obligations from Gmail, Slack, and Calendar into one plan and narrowing each day to a single tiny next action, this design gives open-ended tasks the edges that make starting possible, meets people in tools they already use, and closes the loop from morning to night with rollover so no one opens a blank page. This also prevents the analysis paralysis of having too many things to do so you don't know where to start. The other two realizations solve narrower problems: grayscale apps address distraction, but our participant was clear that "it's not just distraction, it's that you don't want to do it," and the buddy system leans on social accountability, which risks the shame and rejection sensitivity that make ADHD and anxiety users abandon systems in the first place.

5. User Tasks

- 1) Plan today from scattered inputs. Start briefing and gather tasks from Gmail/Slack/Calendar. Goal: go from "something's due somewhere at some time" to a locked top 3 or today, each with a first step. Success: 3 missions chosen, each showing one tiny next step.
- 2) Start the next action. Goal: find and begin the single smallest next step for the priority task, without having to decide what to do. Success: user starts the opener.
- 3) Close out the day and roll over. Goal: log a quick mood, energy, and care check, mark what got done, carry unfinished work forward. Success: reflection saved, unfinished tasks appear in tomorrow's plan.

6. Paper Prototypes

Prototype A: Stepped briefing and dashboard with structured screens, one decision per screen.

Interface. A mobile app with one main full-screen view per stage of the day. Each screen is a dense, scannable surface: the weekly briefing shows source tags (mail, slack, calendar) above a day-grouped list of obligations, the morning briefing groups today's items into due, calendar, and carried-over sections, pick-top-3 is a selectable list, today's missions shows the three chosen tasks each with a tiny next step, and night reflection combines mood and energy dot-scales, care anchors, a done count, and a tomorrow list. Everything on a screen is visible at once, and the user reads and taps directly.

Navigation flow. Linear and forward-moving, screen to screen: This Week → Morning Briefing → Pick top 3 → Today's 3 Missions → Timer → Night Briefing & Reflection.

Task 1 flow:

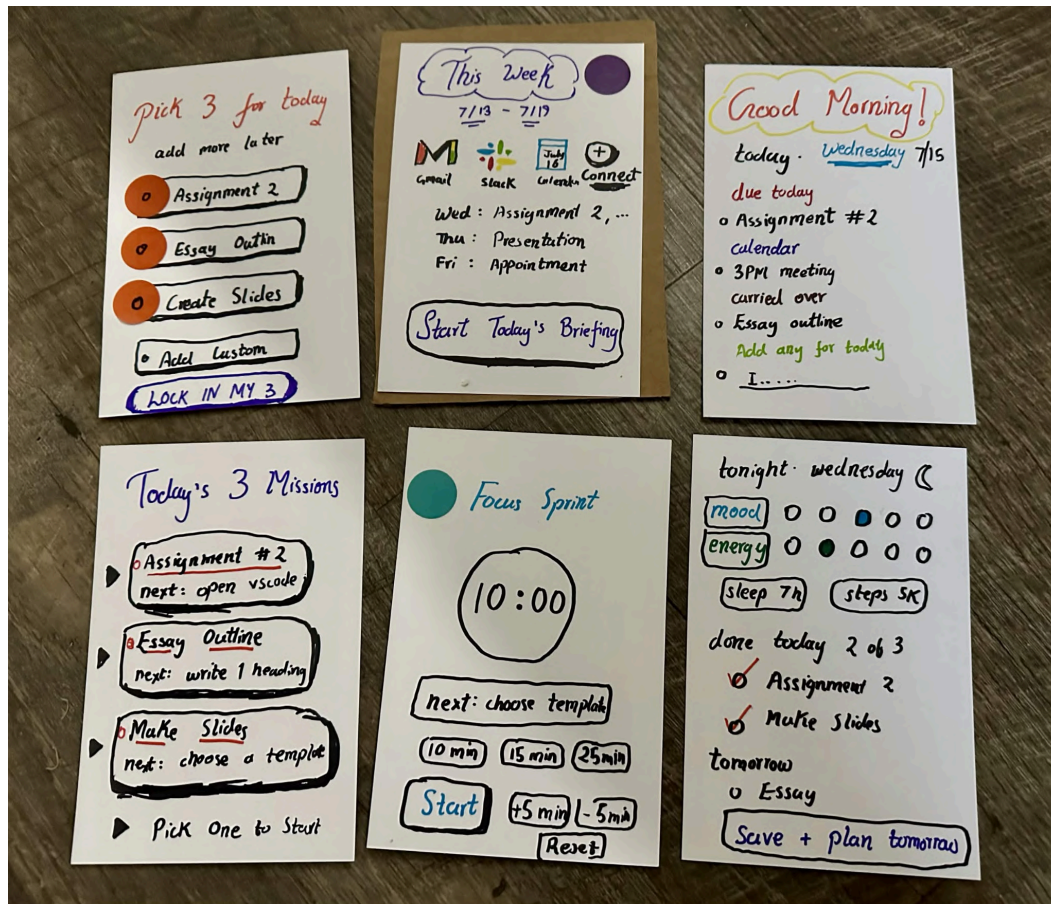
1. Open app, land on This Week, items auto-pulled from Gmail/Slack/Calendar grouped by day.
2. Continue to “Start Morning Briefing” pull items/tasks due today, calendar, carried-over, plus Add Custom for anything not in email/calendar.
3. Continue to Pick top 3, tap 3 items, unpicked ones get a rollover-to-later option.
4. Tap “Lock in my three.”
5. Land on Today’s 3 Missions, each with a tiny next step.

Task 2 flow:

1. On Today’s 3 Missions, the top mission shows it’s “next: open vscode.”
2. Tap the mission to expand its next step and Start.
3. Begin (timer or just the opener).
4. Mark done.

Task 3 flow:

1. Evening notification or open, go to Night Briefing & Reflection.
2. Tap a mood dot, tap an energy dot.
3. Confirm care anchors (sleep, steps, ate, water).
4. See “done today: 2 of 3,” check off completed.
5. Review Tomorrow (unfinished auto-rolled), adjust.
6. Tap “Save + plan tomorrow.”



Prototype B: Conversational co-pilot.

Interface. Voice companion, delivers briefings as a conversational chat thread with quick-reply chips and audio, so planning feels like just answering a few messages.

Navigation flow. A single scrolling chat thread with audio assistant, rather than a sequence of screens.

Task 1 flow:

1. Open app / wear smart glasses, assistant starts a conversational morning briefing greeting "Good Morning John" with a ► audio option, telling you the tasks due today and optionally news headlines.
2. Tap [plan my day] (or ► to listen while doing something else).
3. The assistant posts the surfaced items as chips "tap 3 to focus on, suggested top 3." Tap 3, or confirm/swap top 3 by voice.
4. Tap [lock in 3] or confirm by voice.
5. Assistant replies with the 3, each with a tiny suggested opener.

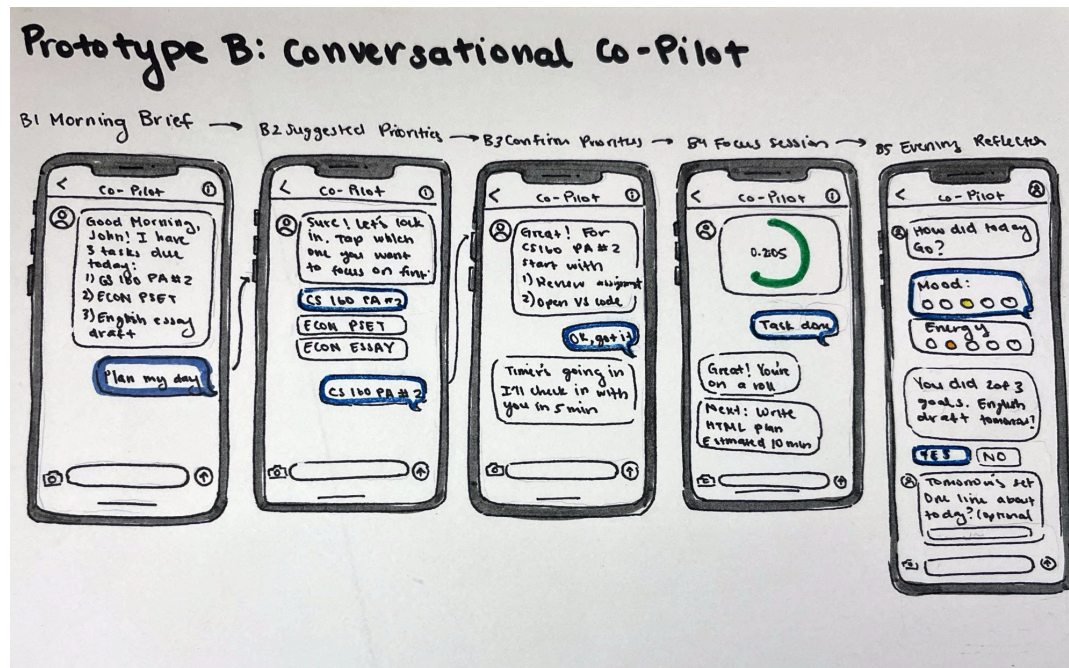
Task 2 flow:

1. Assistant: "next up: CS160 PA#2, just open VSCode. start?" with [start 5 min] / [later].

2. Tap [start 5 min].
3. Assistant: “timer’s going, back in 5.” On done, no sound, just “continue with [next step] or schedule 4 later”

Task 3 flow:

1. Evening, assistant: “how’d today go?” with mood and energy dots.
2. You answer mood and energy verbally (“meh, low energy”) or tap a mood/energy dot.
3. Assistant: “you did 2 of 3. roll ‘essay draft’ to tomorrow?” with [yes] / [no].
4. Tap/Say [yes]. Assistant: “Tomorrow’s set. one line about today?” (optional mini-journal).



How they differ

The main difference between the two prototypes is how users interact with the system and who drives the experience. Prototype A is a sequence of dedicated screens where information is grouped by stage (weekly overview, morning briefing, task selection, today’s mission, and night reflection). Users are given free navigation as they move between pages, selecting items from lists, and tapping buttons to progress through the workflow. By emphasizing visual organization, this prototype allows for greater sense of control over the information but can have a higher risk of an overwhelming interface.

Prototype B replaces these screens with a single conversational interface. Instead of displaying all information at once, the assistant introduces one decision at a time through a chat thread using text, quick-reply chips, optional voice input, and audio playback. Rather than navigating between pages, users respond to prompts as the conversation progresses. This format is intended to

decrease an overwhelming experience and make audio and the reflection feel natural, at the cost of feeling slower or more hand-holding.

7. Testing and Evaluation:

Interview Protocol

Estimated total session length: **10 minutes**

Session Overview & Timing

Section	Time	Goal
Introduction	1 mins	Set expectations, sign consent form, and explain the “think-aloud” process.
Ease-In and Transition	1 min	Get a brief participant self-introduction and ask the needfinding question.
Core User Interaction	3-5 mins	User tests the prototype
Feedback and Wrap-up	5 mins	Gather feedback and positive/negative findings

1) Introduction (2 minutes):

Script to read aloud (adapt as needed):

“Hi, thanks for chatting with us today! We're students in a design class building a tool to help people manage stress, procrastination, and workspace habits.

After doing previous interviews and taking in feedback of what they have tried, we have created a rough paper prototype that addresses issues they brought up. This means that we will provide you with this prototype to interact and then at the end, we would like to see what you think this prototype is used for.

This should take at most 10 minutes and there's no right way to interact, because we want to observe what your approach is. Is it okay if we take notes and record your hands as you use the paper? Everything stays private to our team, and you can be completely honest. Feel free to give any positive or negative feedback! Our goal is to make the optimal experiences for users :) Any questions before we start?”

- ☐ Get verbal consent to record and take notes.
- ☐ Remind them that we are testing our design, not them.
- ☐ Confirm they have about 10 minutes available in case they need to leave early.

2) Ease-In and Transition (2 minutes):

- What do you do?
- Why bring you here this summer?

3) Core User Interaction

- Provide them with prototype
- Ask them to complete each task while thinking aloud

- Observe without leading them unless they become stuck
- Note their hand movements, gestures, and comments they make while thinking aloud

4) Wrap-up (5 min)

“Congrats! You have finished all the tasks!”

- What do you think our app is trying to help people do?
- What parts of this experience did you like the most? Was there anything that felt confusing or difficult?
- If you could change one thing, what would it be?
- Any additional feedback?

“Thank you for your time!”

Team Roles

- Testing Group 1
 - Sampurn Bhowmick: created paper prototype A, interviewed participants, took notes
 - Na Mi Kim: recruited participants, recorded interview
- Testing Group 2
 - Madison Lee: created paper prototype B, recorded interview
 - Thanhbinh Nguyen: created interview protocol, recorded interview, took notes
 - Reed Yalouh: recruited participants, took notes

Prototype A:

Participant 1 – Prototype A: A recent graduate with a master’s degree in journalism and filmmaking who has to keep going between his notebook, laptop, and phone, so often feels overwhelmed and scattered.



Positive findings:

1. He really liked the idea of consolidating every key information/deadline in one place which prevents anxiety by avoiding the back and forth from different platforms. This directly addressed the scattered, multi-device juggling he described at the start.
2. He liked the night reflection at the end of the day, which allows him to review what has been completed and plan what to do tomorrow. The rollover also supported his memory, letting him see what he finished and carry unfinished work into tomorrow.
3. Focus sprint which allows to break down bigger tasks into smaller pieces, decreasing the sense of overwhelm and anxiety of facing everything in the beginning.

Negative findings:

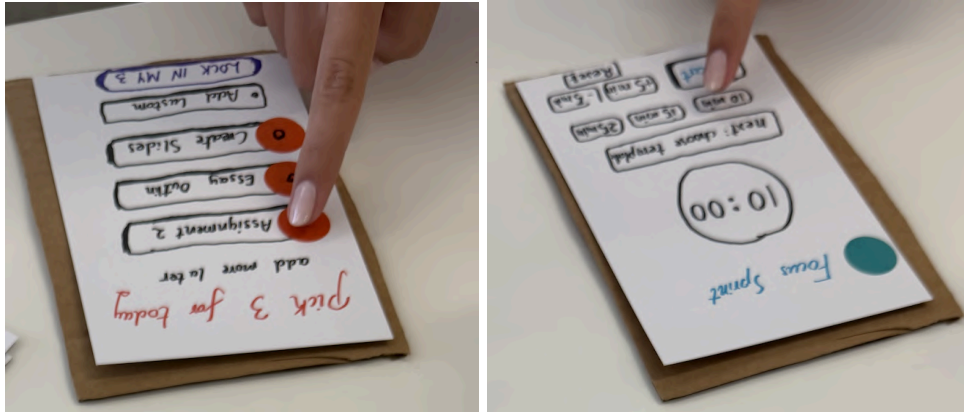
1. (Rating - 2) Focus sprint timer can be added with automatic “Do not Disturb” mode to silence other notifications, so it isn’t cut by interruptions.
2. (Rating - 4) The flow felt complicated on first use, and he wasn’t sure what he was supposed to do.
3. (Rating - 4) Today’s tasks show no specific due time, and not everything is due at 11:59pm, so he couldn’t tell what was actually time-sensitive earlier in the day. Lack of urgency and information about the tasks to be completed.

Additional Feedback:

- Users hope to schedule with notification, location and time.
- He prefers to see today’s tasks page first when opening the app.
- Users emphasized the need for urgency when it comes to the deadline, suggesting adding alerts before the due time.

Participant 2 – Prototype A: An undergraduate student at San Diego State University studying public health, who struggles with minor focus and doomscrolling issues.





Positive findings:

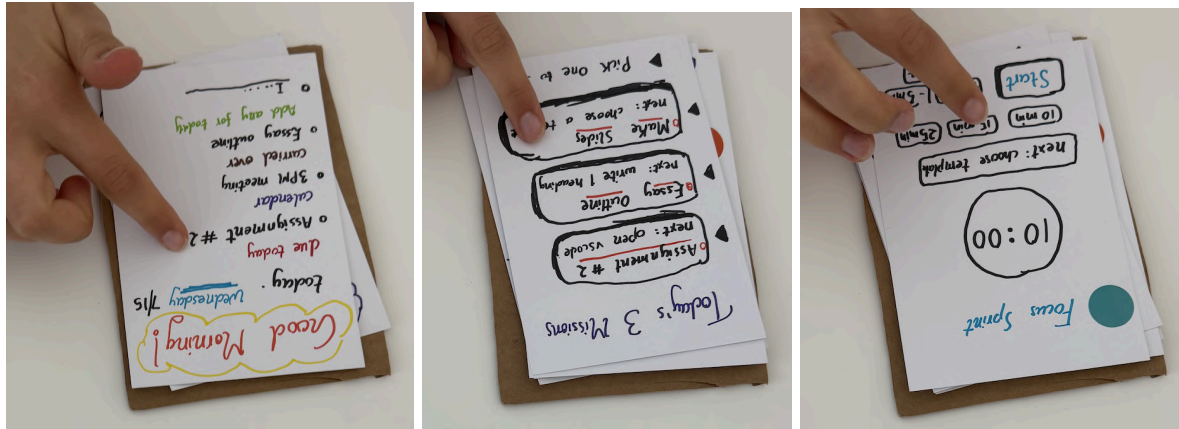
1. She liked the color and visual design, and the idea of seeing everything laid out in one list.
2. The only three tasks displayed on the screen makes the overall day more manageable.
3. Focus sprint timer can minimize the distraction, and can be used for self-pacing.

Negative findings:

1. (Rating - 3) Mood and Energy tracking felt irrelevant to her, since she would use the app purely to focus on work rather than to track feelings.
2. (Rating - 1) Gmail and Calendar were the main integrations that matter to her; she doesn't use Slack, so that connection is unnecessarily shown.
3. (Rating - 3) She didn't know exactly what to press at the start.

Participant 3 – Prototype A: A recent Cal graduate in MCB and Economics, who likes to organize but procrastinates anyway. She traces her problems to perfectionism and delayed gratification, “no satisfaction until an assignment is submitted, which makes starting hard.” The “perfect” plan causes her to struggle with initiation, leading to procrastination. In her words, “Once I start I will finish,” so the main issue in working is initiation.





Positive findings:

1. As she values organization, she found it satisfying to begin the day with a morning briefing with all the important information and deadlines of the day.
2. Display of only 3 tasks motivates her to initiate more easily rather than facing a big load of tasks. The flexibility of adjusting the number of tasks to do depending on the energy makes her feel less constrained. It helped her prioritize and turn “daunting tasks into manageable tasks.” Because she works in bursts and finds sitting down to start the hardest part, picking three eased the initiation, and she said “three is a very intuitive number to keep things manageable.”
3. The overall selection flow felt intuitive and the buttons with bold font made it clear what was tappable.

Negative findings:

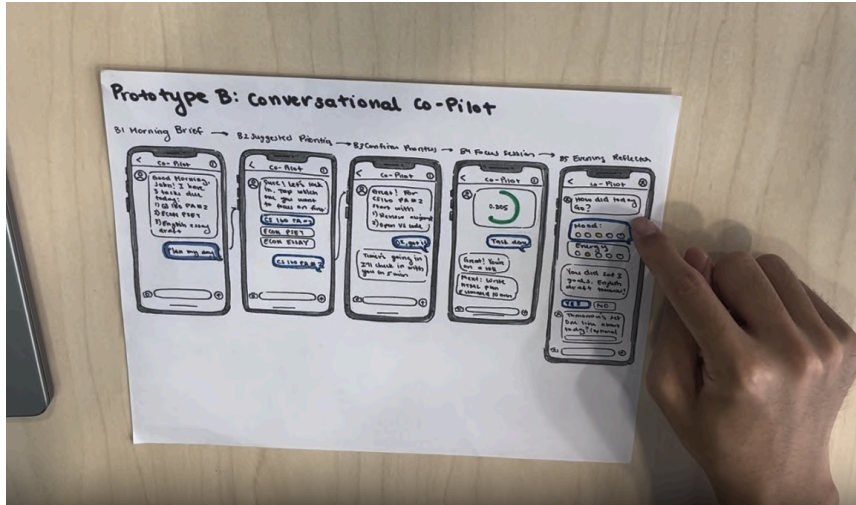
1. (Rating - 3) The “Pick 3” and “Today’s 3 mission” screens look too similar. Making them more visually different would add clarity and make the app more engaging to use.
2. (Rating - 2) The Gmail icon looks clickable, but it doesn’t pull out the Gmail specific information when you click it.
3. (Rating-4) The user is not interested in mood and energy tracking.

Additional Feedback:

- The Pomodoro-style timer is a good idea, but add a reminder with a visual cue when five minutes are left.

Prototype B:

Participant 4 – Prototype B: UC Berkeley upper-division CS course TA and current PhD student, who has used other agents, like ChatGPT to help break down tasks to smaller ones.



Positive findings:

1. It improves time management and makes priorities clear.
2. It helps to break down tasks into smaller, more manageable parts.
3. Copilot nature allows personalization (thought that this would be helpful to anyone, not just if you have concentration/mental issues).

Negative findings:

1. (Rating - 3): user mentioned already using an agent to manage their current task and priorities. So there might not be a reason to get another app if the current workflow is set
2. (Rating - 4): maintenance burden, having to manage things that's supposed to fix management can be burdensome
3. (Rating - 3): the copilot nature of it could introduce an issue in finding it hard to separate work-life boundaries

Participant 5 – Prototype B: 3rd year architecture student at UC Berkeley, who likes to do most of her planning through Google Calendar, as it can be taken and opened anywhere.



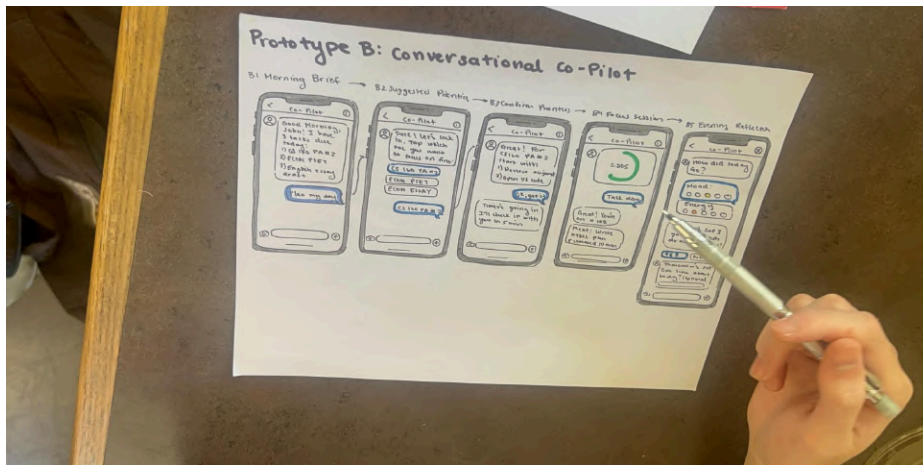
Positive findings:

1. Thought that it would be really helpful for reducing forgotten tasks.
2. Thought that would help to lessen the mental load, everything in one place makes things feel more in control.
3. More organized and structured, which helps folks who struggle with that.

Negative findings:

1. (Rating - 3): the size of text and information – need smarter management/breakdown that's specific to nature of task (information overload)
2. (Rating - 3): the user gets stuck in over planning instead of just tackling the tasks
3. (Rating - 2): Unsure about the reflection scaling (i.e mood, energy)

Participant 6 – Prototype B: 4th year visiting CS student, who has a friend taking CS160 so was aware that these interviews are happening.



Positive findings:

1. The text was clear and intuitive to follow.
2. The sequencing of chats made it clear that outputs are shaped by the user's requests.
3. He appreciated that the straightforward and centralized nature of the solution was geared towards folks dealing with mental health struggles that impede their ability to plan and keep track of things.

Negative findings:

1. (Rating - 3): he thought that the fonts were smaller than they should be. (he points at the last screen, "I'm sorry what does that say one-line?").
2. (Rating - 4): information overload—putting everything they have due in one place can make it intimidating.
3. (Rating - 3): notification fatigue—different platforms/apps feeding into one central one could become a source of interruption.

8. Analysis & Reflection

Major patterns:

Prototype A (App Briefing dashboard):

- Users praised the surface and its visual design.
- They liked seeing everything laid out, and the top-three framing that narrows the day.
- The wins clustered on helping with initiation and consolidation, with the strongest response from the tester whose core struggle is starting.
- The problems were mainly on two things: users didn't know where to begin, and the day's tasks lacked specific times.
- Mood and energy tracking was a recurring unwanted feature.

Prototype B (Conversational Co-Pilot):

- Users like the idea of starting from small first.
- Maintenance burden concern
- Information Overload
- Not competitive enough to encourage users to prioritize this method over their current methods

Common Patterns: Across both, the core idea (consolidate scattered obligations, narrow to a next action) consistently landed, while the failure modes were about how much the app shows and asks. Users value simplicity and easy navigation while under the circumstances of dealing with tasks.

Success:

1. Consolidation. Putting multiple scattered obligations/tasks into one place was appreciated by nearly everyone (P1, P2, P5, P6), and directly answered the overwhelm with multi-device and "something is due" scatter anxiety.
2. Only 3 tasks to begin with at one time. Building more confidence and less anxious overthinking rather than seeing the whole big tasks in front of them. (P1, P2, P3, P4)
3. Focus sprint. Getting in the mood without thinking too much. (P1, P2, P3)
4. Rollover tasks. Carrying unfinished tasks to tomorrow automatically helps memory and reduces forgotten task anxiety (P1, P5).
5. Tiny next steps. Breaking work into a small next action was said to be helpful in making daunting tasks manageable (P3, P4).
6. Clarity of the copilot chat flow. The chat sequencing made it clear that outputs follow the user's input (P4, P6), and users noted that it would help anyone, not only people with focus struggles.

Common usability issues:

1. Start confusion/ambiguity. P1 (“what am I supposed to do”), P2 (“not sure what to press”), P3 (start ambiguity).
2. Timer gaps, minor but a recurring request. P1 and P3 wanted do-not-disturb, notification control, and a visual cue at five minutes left.
3. Mood and Energy tracking not wanted, moderate and recurring (P2, P3, P5). Focus-only users did not want to track feelings.
4. No due time within today (P1).
5. Pick 3 and Today’s 3 missions look alike (P3).
6. False affordances with buttons, minor. P3 pressed the Gmail icon in the weekly overview screen expecting Gmail-specific tasks, because the source icon reads as a button.
7. Text/handwriting was small, so clarifications was asked (P5, P6)
8. Burden of adjusting the task plan (P4, P5)

Planned changes for next iteration:

1. Fix the entry point. Open on today’s morning briefing screen by default (P1).
2. Add a guided first run for better affordance, and make one obvious “start here” action.
3. Make the gmail/calendar/slack connections into buttons that show specific information from those platforms.
4. Remove mood and energy tracking or make it optional. Add trends related to sleep, movement and tasks completed, so the health tracking in the reflection screen feels useful.
5. Differentiate the two selection screens (Pick 3 vs Today’s 3 Missions) visually, or improve the flow to make it more intuitive.
6. Add time to tasks. Per-task due times, scheduling with time and optional location, and alerts before the deadline.
7. Add an option to zoom in and out with text in the conversational co-pilot, and add a pause and rest option.
8. Personalize integrations to what the users actually use. P2 doesn’t use Slack, so showing a slack logo on the main screen was unnecessary information.